Haligric Research Integration Series

CHRISTIAN MISSIONARY TRADITIONS

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Great Commission, the Three Waves, the Colonial Entanglement, the Global South Reversal, and the Ongoing Debate About What Mission Is For

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William Carey went to India in 1793 and is called the Father of Modern Missions. He translated the Bible into Bengali and six other languages, established schools, advocated against widow-burning, and changed the standard of what missionary work meant. Hudson Taylor went to inland China in 1865 and changed the strategy: live like the people, learn their language, give your life to it. Jim Elliot went to the Huaorani people of Ecuador in 1956, was speared to death five days after contact, and became the most famous missionary martyr of the 20th century. His killers became Christians. His wife returned to live among them. This is not a simple story. It never has been.

Christian mission is the engine that created the global church — the institution responsible for the spread of Christianity from a first-century Jewish movement in Palestine to the largest religion on earth, with 2.6 billion adherents on every continent. It is also the institution most intimately entangled with colonialism, cultural destruction, and the systematic dismantling of indigenous sacred traditions. Both things are true simultaneously, and any honest account of the missionary tradition must hold them both.

This document covers the theology, the history, the organizations, the ethics, and the present state of Christian mission — with specific attention to what the missionary encounter has meant for the communities whose sacred traditions appear elsewhere in this series. It is a companion to the Christian Denominations document and to every tradition in this library whose community has encountered Christian missionaries.

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Introduction

The Most Consequential Institution in Modern Religious History

No institution has done more to shape the religious map of the modern world than the Christian missionary movement. No institution has been more ambiguously beneficial and more genuinely harmful at the same time. The story of Christian mission is the story of extraordinary individual courage and self-sacrifice alongside systematic cultural destruction. It is the story of the most rapid spread of a religion in human history alongside the suppression of the most diverse collection of indigenous sacred traditions ever assembled. It is the story of an institution that built schools and hospitals in places that had neither and that also presided over the deliberate elimination of languages, ceremonies, and cosmologies that had organized human communities for millennia.

This document does not resolve this tension. The tension is the subject. The goal is to give the reader the fullest possible account of what the missionary tradition is, how it works, what it has accomplished, what it has destroyed, and what its practitioners and critics have said about all of the above. The Haligricity series covers dozens of traditions that have been touched by Christian mission — from the Ari of Ethiopia (where SIM missionaries worked from the 1950s, producing what they describe as the most complete conversion of any Omo Valley people) to the Hawaiian tradition (where Congregationalist missionaries arrived in 1820 and within a generation had remade the political and sacred landscape of the islands) to the Cherokee (where the American Board of Commissioners for Foreign Missions established schools and a printing press, enabling the Sequoyah syllabary that the Cherokees had developed, before the Trail of Tears displaced the communities those same missionaries had built). The missionary encounter is present in more of these documents than any other single external force.

Reading this document alongside those tradition-specific accounts will give the fullest picture of what mission has meant in practice — not in the abstract but in the specific communities whose specific sacred worlds are the subject of this library.

What Is Mission? The Theological Foundation

Missio Dei — The Mission of God

The theological foundation of Christian mission is the concept of missio Dei — the mission of God. The phrase, developed in 20th-century missiology (the academic study of mission), expresses the understanding that the mission to bring the whole world into relationship with God is not primarily the church's mission but God's mission — and that the church participates in it. Vatican II's declaration that "the pilgrim Church is missionary by her very nature" captures the same idea: mission is not an optional activity of a church that is primarily something else. Mission is what the church is for.

Before the missio Dei concept was formalized, the dominant understanding was more straightforwardly institutional: the church was sent to save souls, and the vehicle for that saving was the church's own expansion. The missio Dei framework shifted the center of gravity from church expansion to divine purpose — which, in the more generous readings, opened the door for a broader understanding of mission that included social justice, poverty relief, education, and healthcare as expressions of God's mission rather than merely as tools for making converts.

Contemporary missiology distinguishes between evangelism (the proclamation of the Christian gospel, focused on bringing people to personal faith in Christ) and holistic or integral mission (the engagement with the full range of human need — physical, social, political, spiritual — as an expression of the kingdom of God). These two emphases are in tension within the missionary tradition and have been debated explicitly at every major missionary conference since the 1960s.

The Three Theological Questions of Mission

Three theological questions organize the missionary tradition's internal debates. First: who needs to be reached? The narrowest answer is the unevangelized — those who have never heard the Christian gospel. The broadest is the entire human race, which in Christian theology stands in need of reconciliation with God. The answer to this question determines the scope and urgency of mission.

Second: what does being reached mean? The narrowest answer is conversion — the individual decision to accept Christ as savior, resulting in eternal life. The broadest is transformation — the healing and restoration of individuals, communities, and entire social structures through the presence of the kingdom of God. The answer to this question determines what missionaries do.

Third: how should the gospel be presented? The most restrictive answer is in its received Western form, unchanged by cultural context. The most contextually sensitive is in forms that emerge from and speak to the specific culture of the people being reached. This is the contextualization debate, addressed in its own section below.

The Great Commission and Its Interpretations

Go Therefore and Make Disciples — Matthew 28:18-20

The primary scriptural authorization for Christian mission is the Great Commission — the instruction attributed to the risen Jesus to his disciples in Matthew 28:18-20: "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, and teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you." This text is the most cited, most debated, and most acted-upon passage in the New Testament for the missionary tradition.

What the text says is clear. What it means is contested. Who counts as "all nations" (Greek: panta ta ethne — all peoples, all ethnic groups)? Does "make disciples" mean convince individuals or transform communities? What does "teaching them to obey everything I have commanded" license in terms of cultural change? For 2,000 years of missionary history, the answers have varied enormously — and the specific answers adopted by specific missionaries at specific historical moments have determined what they did when they arrived in a new community.

The most expansive interpretation: the Great Commission licenses the total transformation of every aspect of every culture to bring it into conformity with Christian teaching. This reading has justified everything from the destruction of indigenous sacred sites to the prohibition of traditional ceremonies to the enforced wearing of Western clothing. The most minimal interpretation: the Great Commission licenses the proclamation of the Christian gospel and leaves everything else to the sovereign work of the Holy Spirit in the communities that receive it. Most missionaries have operated somewhere between these poles.

The 10/40 Window and the Unreached Peoples Concept

Two concepts from modern missiology have organized the contemporary missionary movement's strategic thinking. The 10/40 Window — coined by missionary strategist Luis Bush in 1990 — refers to the geographic band between 10 and 40 degrees north latitude, from West Africa to East Asia, which contains the largest concentrations of people who are not Christian: Muslims, Hindus, Buddhists, and animists. The term "window" suggests that this is where the church's missionary attention should be concentrated.

The Unreached Peoples concept — developed by Donald McGavran and Ralph Winter at the US Center for World Mission, with Winter's 1974 presentation at the Lausanne Congress on World Evangelization as its public debut — argues that the fundamental unit of mission should not be geographic nations but ethnic and linguistic people groups, and that a people group is "unreached" when it does not have an indigenous church capable of evangelizing the rest of the group without outside assistance. The Joshua Project, which tracks "unreached people groups" globally, currently identifies approximately 7,400 such groups, comprising roughly 3.2 billion people.

The Three Classic Waves of Protestant Mission

From the Coast to the Interior to the Unreached

The history of Protestant mission is conventionally organized into three waves, each associated with a specific strategy, a specific geography, and a specific pioneering figure. The wave model is a simplification — missionary activity in each phase overlaps with and continues into subsequent phases — but it captures the major shifts in strategic emphasis that have characterized the Protestant missionary movement over two and a half centuries.

The wave framework was developed by Ralph Winter and has been adopted widely in missiological literature. It provides a useful structural overview while acknowledging that real missionary history is messier than any three-wave model can capture.

Wave One — The Coastal Mission (1792–1865)

William Carey and the Birth of the Modern Missionary Movement

The first wave of modern Protestant mission is conventionally dated to 1792, when William Carey — a Baptist cobbler and self-taught linguist from Northamptonshire, England — published An Enquiry into the Obligations of Christians to Use Means for the Conversion of the Heathens and organized the Baptist Missionary Society. The following year, Carey sailed to India, where he would spend 41 years without a furlough, translating the Bible into Bengali, Sanskrit, and 35 other languages, establishing the Serampore Mission, founding what would become one of the oldest colleges in Asia (Serampore College, 1818), and campaigning against sati (widow immolation) — contributing to the legislation that outlawed it in 1829.

Carey is called the Father of Modern Missions not because he was the first Protestant missionary (earlier figures, including the Moravian Brethren and the Danish-Halle Mission, preceded him by decades) but because he established the model that defined Protestant mission for the next century: the voluntary missionary society, supported by home churches through regular financial contribution, sending long-term career missionaries to specific geographic fields. The London Missionary Society (1795), the Church Missionary Society (1799), and dozens of subsequent organizations followed Carey's model.

The first wave focused primarily on coastal areas accessible to the trading and colonial infrastructure of European powers — India, West Africa, the Pacific Islands, Southeast Asia. The missionaries of the first wave were products of their era: they assumed the superiority of Western civilization and Christianity together, and their mission typically involved not just preaching but the creation of schools, the translation of texts, and the systematic introduction of European cultural practices alongside the Christian gospel. The distinction between the religious and cultural content of their mission was, for most of them, invisible or unimportant.

Key figures of the first wave include Robert Morrison (first Protestant missionary to China, 1807), Henry Martyn (India and Persia), Adoniram Judson (Burma/Myanmar), and Lottie Moon (China, whose fundraising legacy created the largest international mission offering in American Christianity — the Lottie Moon Christmas Offering still funds thousands of Southern Baptist missionaries annually).

Wave Two — The Inland Mission (1865–1934)

Hudson Taylor and the Penetration of the Interior

The second wave is associated with Hudson Taylor and the founding of the China Inland Mission (CIM) in 1865. The strategic insight: the coastal cities of the world were being reached, but the vast interior populations — hundreds of millions of people in China's inland provinces, in the interior of Africa, in the Amazon basin — had no missionary presence. Taylor's solution was to abandon the coastal mission station model and send missionaries into the interior to live among the people they were trying to reach.

Taylor is credited with two innovations that defined the second wave. First, the living-like-the-people principle: Taylor scandalized many of his contemporaries by wearing Chinese clothing, adopting Chinese hairstyles (including the queue required by the Qing dynasty), speaking the local language, and eating local food. His argument was that the missionary's foreignness was itself a barrier to the gospel — if you appeared to be representing a foreign culture, you would not be heard by people who resented that culture. This was an early form of contextualization.

Second, the faith mission model: Taylor's China Inland Mission operated without guaranteed salaries. Missionaries were expected to trust God for their financial provision rather than being supported by a denominational structure. This model attracted a different kind of missionary — often more theologically conservative, less connected to institutional church structures, more willing to accept physical hardship — and gave rise to dozens of "faith missions" that operated outside the major denominational structures.

The second wave produced some of the most famous names in missionary history: David Livingstone (Africa), Mary Slessor (Nigeria), C. T. Studd and the "Cambridge Seven" (China), Jim Elliot (Ecuador). It also produced the most dramatic martyrdom narratives in modern missionary history — stories of missionaries killed by the communities they were trying to reach, which in turn generated waves of new missionary volunteers. The Auca Mission (1956), in which five missionaries including Jim Elliot were killed by the Huaorani people of Ecuador, is the most famous such narrative. The subsequent return of the missionaries' wives and the eventual conversion of the Huaorani became a standard missionary recruitment story for decades.

The second wave's peak period was the Student Volunteer Movement (SVM), which from 1886 to 1936 mobilized over 100,000 students for missionary service with the slogan "the evangelization of the world in this generation." At its peak in 1906, 2,500 SVM members went to the mission field in a single year. The movement's decline paralleled the Fundamentalist-Modernist controversy in American Protestantism, which split the missionary movement between theologically conservative and theologically liberal wings.

Wave Three — The Unreached Peoples Movement (1934–Present)

Cameron Townsend, Donald McGavran, and the Strategic Revolution

The third wave is associated with two innovations that combined to redirect the entire missionary enterprise. The first was Cameron Townsend's founding of the Summer Institute of Linguistics (SIL) in 1934, which eventually became the organizational complex of Wycliffe Bible Translators and SIL International. Townsend's insight was that Bible translation into the mother tongue of every language group was the prerequisite for indigenous Christianity — people could not be discipled in a gospel they could not read in their own language. Wycliffe/SIL became one of the most linguistically significant organizations in the history of scholarship, contributing to the documentation of hundreds of endangered languages while pursuing the translation of the Bible into all of them.

The second innovation was Donald McGavran's church growth theory, which he developed through decades of fieldwork in India and published in The Bridges of God (1955) and Understanding Church Growth (1970). McGavran's central argument was that people become Christians most naturally in groups, along existing social networks and family lines, rather than as isolated individuals crossing cultural barriers. This "homogeneous unit principle" — the observation that people prefer to worship with people like themselves — became both the most influential and the most contested idea in 20th-century missiology.

The third wave was consolidated at the 1974 Lausanne Congress on World Evangelization, where Ralph Winter presented the Unreached Peoples concept and effectively reoriented the entire evangelical missionary movement toward the question of ethnolinguistic people groups rather than geographic nations. The strategic implication: a country might have churches and be considered "reached" at a national level while containing dozens of ethnic groups with no Christian presence. The mission task was not completed when a country had some Christians — it was completed (in this framework) only when every people group had an indigenous church.

The Catholic Mission Tradition

From the Jesuits to Vatican II — A Parallel and Ancient Story

The Protestant three-wave framework can obscure the reality that Catholic mission preceded, paralleled, and in some regions far exceeded Protestant mission in both scope and duration. By the time William Carey sailed to India in 1793, Catholic missionaries had been working in the Americas for 300 years, in Asia for nearly as long, and in Africa for centuries.

The Catholic mission tradition is organized differently from the Protestant one. Rather than voluntary mission societies organized by laypeople and supported by congregational giving, Catholic mission is organized through religious orders — the Dominicans, Franciscans, Augustinians, Capuchins, and most significantly the Society of Jesus (Jesuits) — whose members take vows of obedience and poverty, live in community, and are deployed at the direction of their superiors. This institutional structure gave Catholic mission an organizational coherence and a long-term commitment to specific fields that Protestant mission societies sometimes struggled to match.

The specific character of Catholic mission has also been shaped by Vatican decisions in ways that Protestant mission has not. The Rites Controversy of the 17th–18th centuries — in which the papacy ultimately condemned the Jesuit accommodation of Chinese and Indian cultural practices — established a precedent of centralized control over missionary methodology that shaped Catholic mission for two centuries. Vatican II (1962–1965) reversed many of these restrictions, declaring the church missionary by nature and explicitly endorsing contextualization — the adaptation of Christian practice to local cultural forms.

The modern Catholic missionary order most directly relevant to communities in this series is the Consolata Missionary Institute (IMC), which has worked extensively in Kenya, Tanzania, Ethiopia, and other East African countries, and the White Fathers (Missionaries of Africa, founded 1868 by Cardinal Lavigerie), who pioneered Catholic mission in sub-Saharan Africa with a specific commitment to learning local languages and culture. The Comboni Missionaries, founded by Bishop Daniel Comboni in 1867 for Sudan and Africa, are particularly active in Omo Valley adjacent regions of Ethiopia and South Sudan.

The Jesuit Experiment — Contextualization Before the Word Existed

Matteo Ricci in China and Roberto de Nobili in India

The most dramatic example of pre-modern contextualization — and the one whose condemnation by Rome set back Catholic mission strategy by two centuries — is the work of Jesuit missionaries in China and India in the 16th and 17th centuries.

Matteo Ricci (1552–1610) arrived in China in 1582 and spent the rest of his life working his way to Beijing and into the intellectual life of the Ming dynasty court. His method was to present Christianity as compatible with Confucian ethics, to dress as a Confucian scholar, to engage Chinese intellectuals on scientific and philosophical terms, and to minimize the cultural foreignness of the Christian message. He introduced Western science and mathematics to China, corresponded with the leading intellectuals of the dynasty, and was eventually given permission to remain in Beijing — the first European permitted to live in the imperial capital. He described the Chinese ancestral veneration ceremonies as civic rather than religious, arguing that Chinese Christians could participate in them without violating Christian faith.

Roberto de Nobili (1577–1656) arrived in India and adopted the practice of a Brahmin sannyasi — wearing saffron robes, eating only vegetarian food, learning Sanskrit and Tamil, and presenting Christianity in the terms of Indian philosophy. He was the first European to study Sanskrit seriously, and his linguistic work preceded European Sanskrit scholarship by nearly two centuries.

Both Ricci and de Nobili were condemned — de Nobili during his own lifetime, Ricci's methods condemned posthumously in 1715 by Pope Clement XI's Bulla Ex illa die, which prohibited Chinese Christians from participating in ancestral rites. The condemnation is known as the Rites Controversy. Its practical consequence was the expulsion of the Jesuits from China and the collapse of what had been a promising Chinese Christianity. The missionary strategies that Ricci and de Nobili had pioneered — respect for the host culture, engagement on its own intellectual terms, allowance for cultural continuity — did not become official Catholic policy until Vatican II, 250 years later.

Major Missionary Organizations

The Institutional Architecture of the Modern Missionary Movement

SIM (Serving in Mission) — Founded 1893

Founded in 1893 as the Soudan Interior Mission (SIM) by three young men — Walter Gowans and Thomas Kent (who died of malaria shortly after arriving in Nigeria) and Rowland Bingham (who survived and returned to Canada to rebuild the organization) — with the explicit goal of reaching the interior of West Africa. SIM expanded over the 20th century through mergers with other missions, becoming one of the largest interdenominational evangelical mission organizations in the world, currently deploying approximately 4,000 missionaries in more than 75 countries across six continents. SIM is the specific organization that conducted the intensive missionary work among the Ari people of Ethiopia beginning in the 1950s, described in the Ari volume of this series.

International Mission Board (IMB) — Founded 1845

The Foreign Mission Board of the Southern Baptist Convention (renamed the International Mission Board in 1997) is the largest Protestant mission organization in the United States and one of the largest in the world. Founded in 1845 — the same year that Southern Baptists separated from Northern Baptists over the question of slaveholding missionaries — the IMB currently deploys approximately 3,500 career missionaries globally. Its focus has shifted from geographic countries to people groups, with a specific emphasis on church planting movements among unreached peoples. The IMB reports that in one recent year its personnel engaged with 77,605 people overseas who accepted Christ and saw 13,898 new churches planted.

Wycliffe Bible Translators / SIL International — Founded 1934

Founded by William Cameron Townsend as the Summer Institute of Linguistics in 1934, Wycliffe/SIL is the most linguistically significant missionary organization in history. Its mandate is the translation of the Bible into every language — currently approximately 7,000 languages are spoken in the world, with the complete Bible existing in about 700 and portions (New Testament or smaller) in approximately 3,400. SIL International (the secular arm, which conducts linguistic research and works with governments) and Wycliffe Bible Translators (the missionary arm) operate as parallel organizations, a dual structure that has allowed SIL to work in countries that prohibit missionary activity by presenting itself as a linguistic research organization.

Operation Mobilization (OM) — Founded 1957

Founded by George Verwer, who converted at age 16 at a Billy Graham crusade and organized his first mission trip to Mexico with two friends in 1957. OM pioneered the short-term mission model and the ship ministry (MV Logos, launched 1970, and its successors), and currently mobilizes approximately 6,800 workers in 118 countries. Verwer, who died in 2023, was one of the most influential figures in 20th-century evangelical mission mobilization.

The Missionary Alliance (Christian and Missionary Alliance — CMA) — Founded 1887

Founded by A.B. Simpson with a specific focus on reaching the unreached peoples of the world, the CMA pioneered work in multiple regions of Asia, Africa, and Latin America and developed one of the strongest indigenous church-planting models in Protestant mission. The Alliance's emphasis on establishing self-supporting, self-governing, and self-propagating indigenous churches (the "three-self" model, developed independently by Henry Venn and Rufus Anderson in the 19th century) has been one of the most influential principles in modern missiology.

The Missionary Sisters — Women in Mission

Women have constituted the majority of Protestant missionaries for most of the movement's history — a fact that the male-centric narrative of missionary leadership tends to obscure. Lottie Moon (China), Amy Carmichael (India), Mary Slessor (Nigeria), and Helen Roseveare (Congo) are among the most famous women missionaries, but they represent a much larger reality: women who founded hospitals, schools, orphanages, and community development organizations that continue to operate in their original fields. The Catholic mission tradition has similarly been sustained by women religious — the Missionary Sisters of Our Lady of Africa, the Medical Mission Sisters, and dozens of other congregations whose work in education and healthcare has been the most lasting material legacy of the missionary movement in many communities.

The Lausanne Movement and Integral Mission

Billy Graham, John Stott, and the 1974 Congress

The most significant organizing event in 20th-century evangelical mission was the International Congress on World Evangelization, held in Lausanne, Switzerland in July 1974, convened by Billy Graham and organized intellectually by the theologian John Stott. 2,700 participants from 150 countries gathered to address the question: what is the relationship between evangelism and social responsibility? Can — and should — the missionary movement engage with poverty, injustice, and political oppression, or should its mandate be limited to the proclamation of the gospel?

The Lausanne Covenant, drafted primarily by John Stott, represents the most carefully crafted attempt to balance these concerns in the evangelical tradition. It affirms the primacy of evangelism while simultaneously declaring that "socio-political involvement" is "part of our Christian duty" and that "evangelism and sociopolitical involvement are both part of our Christian duty." The covenant introduced the concept of "integral mission" — the understanding that evangelism and social action are inseparable expressions of the same gospel — into evangelical missiology.

The covenant also addressed the relationship between the gospel and culture in Paragraph 10, acknowledging that "missions have all too frequently exported with the gospel an alien culture" — a remarkable admission from a movement that had often equated the gospel with Western civilization. The Lausanne Congress of 1974 is the moment when evangelical missiology formally acknowledged the contextualization question and committed itself to wrestling with it.

The Lausanne Movement has continued through subsequent congresses (Manila 1989, Cape Town 2010, Seoul 2024) and through a continuous stream of documents addressing specific missiological challenges. The Cape Town Commitment (2010) is the most recent comprehensive statement, addressing diaspora missions, creation care, the role of the church in public life, and the specific challenges of mission in Muslim, Hindu, and Buddhist contexts.

Bible Translation — Wycliffe and the SIL

The Most Consequential Linguistic Enterprise in Human History

The effort to translate the Christian Bible into every human language is simultaneously the most linguistically significant missionary project in history and one of the most ethically complex. The positive case: Bible translation has contributed more to the documentation, preservation, and formal status of indigenous languages than any other single institution. SIL linguists have produced the first written grammars, the first dictionaries, and the first published texts in hundreds of languages that had previously existed only in oral form. The Ethnologue, SIL's comprehensive catalog of the world's languages, is the standard reference in linguistics.

The ethically complex case: Bible translation is not a neutral linguistic exercise. It is the translation of a specific text for a specific purpose — producing a scripture that will be used to promote Christianity in the target language community. The choice of which language gets documented and which text gets translated into it is not random. In some documented cases, the availability of Bible translation in a language has been accompanied by the suppression of other forms of oral tradition in the same language — not because the translators intended this, but because the prestige of the written text in the mission church context often elevated the biblical text at the expense of the community's oral sacred tradition.

The SIL's dual-organization structure — presenting the Summer Institute of Linguistics as a secular linguistic research body to governments that would not permit missionary work — has been a persistent source of controversy. In Mexico, Ecuador, Brazil, and Peru, indigenous rights organizations and governments have accused SIL of conducting missionary work under the cover of linguistic research, gaining access to indigenous communities on false pretenses. Mexico expelled SIL in 1979. Brazil suspended its operations in 1977. The dual-organization model is defended by Wycliffe/SIL as a legitimate institutional arrangement that allows linguistic work to proceed in restricted access contexts; it is criticized by others as a form of institutional deception.

The African Independent Churches

The Indigenous Response — Christianity Without the Missionary

One of the most significant developments in global Christian history is the emergence of the African Independent Churches (AICs) — also called African Initiated, Indigenous, or Instituted Churches — the thousands of Christian communities that Africans founded, outside the control of Western missionary organizations, beginning in the late 19th century and continuing through the present day. The AICs are simultaneously the most significant indigenous Christian movement in history and the most dramatic evidence that the missionary enterprise, having planted Christianity in Africa, lost control of it.

The AICs emerged from a specific frustration. Western mission churches excluded Africans from leadership positions, prohibited African cultural practices as "pagan," conducted worship in European languages or in stilted African translations of European liturgy, and maintained a racial paternalism that made African Christians colonial subjects within their own faith. African Christians responded by founding their own churches — led by Africans, conducted in African languages, incorporating African music and cultural practices, and engaging with the specific spiritual concerns (healing, ancestral veneration, witchcraft, community harmony) that the mission churches systematically ignored.

The major types of AICs reflect the specific concerns they addressed. Ethiopian churches (named not for the country but for the symbolic independence associated with Psalm 68:31 — "Ethiopia shall soon stretch out her hands to God") focused on African political and ecclesiastical independence from European control, maintaining orthodox Protestant or Catholic theology while demanding African leadership. Zionist and Apostolic churches (drawing on the American Zionist movement that arrived in South Africa around 1900) emphasized healing, prophecy, and the power of the Holy Spirit — providing a specifically African form of Pentecostal Christianity that addressed illness and misfortune in terms that resonated with indigenous cosmologies. Prophet-healing churches formed around charismatic African prophets who combined Christian faith with African healing traditions.

The scale of the AIC movement is remarkable. By 1981, AICs constituted 15% of the total Christian population in sub-Saharan Africa. Current estimates suggest over 83 million AIC adherents and more than 5,000 distinct AIC denominations in Southern Africa alone. The Zion Apostolic Church and the AmaNazaretha Church in Southern Africa each have memberships of approximately 5 million. The Aladura churches of West Africa (centered in Nigeria) add millions more. The AICs are growing faster than both the historic mission churches and the newer Pentecostal denominations in most of the contexts where they operate.

The Global South Reversal

The Mission Field Becomes the Mission Sender

The most dramatic development in contemporary Christian mission is the reversal of the missionary flow. For 500 years, Christian mission moved from Europe and North America to the rest of the world — from the "sending countries" of the West to the "receiving countries" of Africa, Asia, and Latin America. This pattern has been fundamentally disrupted. As of 2025, an estimated 69% of all Christians live in the Global South, compared to a Europe-and-North-America-dominated faith just a century ago. The center of Christian life has moved.

With this demographic shift has come a missional reversal. African, Asian, and Latin American churches are now sending missionaries to the West — a phenomenon called "reverse mission" that would have been inconceivable to the missionaries of the first and second waves. Nigerian Pentecostal churches conduct aggressive evangelism in London. Brazilian evangelical mission agencies deploy workers to Portugal and Portugal's former African colonies. South Korean missionaries constitute the second-largest national missionary force in the world after the United States, with approximately 23,000 Korean missionaries deployed in 169 countries. The Filipino missionary force — largely invisible in Western mission statistics — serves in hundreds of countries, many of them accessing contexts that Western missionaries cannot.

The emergence of the Majority World as a missionary sender has complicated the old categories. The new Global South missionaries are not immune to the paternalism and cultural imperialism that marked earlier waves of Western mission — South Korean missionaries in Africa and the Middle East have been criticized for some of the same patterns that characterized Western mission at its worst. But the diversity of the contemporary missionary movement — its multiple centers, its many languages, its variety of theological emphases — represents a genuinely new phase in missionary history.

The World Christian Encyclopedia estimates that global mission sending is now more distributed than at any previous point in Christian history, with significant sending from Brazil, South Korea, the Philippines, Nigeria, China, and India alongside the traditional senders of the United States, United Kingdom, and continental Europe. The fastest-growing mission movements are charismatic and Pentecostal, reflecting the broader growth of those expressions of Christianity in the Global South.

Mission and Colonialism — The Entanglement

The Most Difficult Question in Mission History

The relationship between Christian mission and European colonialism is the most contested and most important question in the history of the missionary movement. The honest answer is: the relationship was close, complex, mutually reinforcing, sometimes resistant, and ultimately inseparable in most of the historical record.

The structural entanglement was real and documented. Missionary presence often preceded colonial administration — missionaries were frequently the first outsiders to establish sustained contact with indigenous communities, and their presence created the conditions (language knowledge, community relationships, physical infrastructure) that colonial administrators subsequently used. Colonial administration often relied on missionary-educated indigenous intermediaries. Missionaries relied on colonial authority to protect their physical safety and their right to operate. The two institutions were not identical — missionaries and colonial officials frequently clashed over the treatment of indigenous peoples — but they moved through the same landscape with mutually reinforcing presuppositions about the superiority of Western civilization and the backwardness of indigenous cultures.

The theological entanglement was equally real. The assumption that non-Christian religious practice was the work of demonic forces — standard theology in most missionary traditions until well into the 20th century — provided religious authorization for the suppression of indigenous sacred traditions that colonial administration found politically convenient to prohibit. When a missionary characterized traditional ceremonies as "devil worship," they were making a theological claim that also happened to align perfectly with the colonial administrator's interest in disrupting the social cohesion that traditional ceremonies helped maintain.

The important qualifications: not all missionaries were colonialists and not all colonialists welcomed missionaries. William Wilberforce and the Clapham Sect, the evangelical Christian abolitionists who drove the campaign to end the British slave trade, were products of the same missionary movement. David Livingstone's African explorations were motivated in part by his revulsion at the Arab and Portuguese slave trade. Bartolomé de las Casas, the 16th-century Dominican friar, spent his life defending the indigenous peoples of the Caribbean and Americas against Spanish colonial violence — and was himself a missionary. The record is not uniformly destructive. But the record is not uniformly innocent either, and the honest account requires holding both.

What Was Lost — Cultural Destruction

The Specific Costs of the Missionary Encounter

Reading the tradition-specific documents in this series against the history of missionary activity reveals a specific and consistent pattern: in community after community, the missionary encounter resulted in the prohibition or suppression of exactly the elements of the tradition that this series identifies as most sacred. The ceremonies. The dances. The cosmological frameworks. The healing traditions. The ancestral veneration. The sacred specialists. These were the primary targets of the missionary critique, because they were the primary expressions of the sacred world that Christianity was supposed to replace.

The Hawaiian case is one of the most documented. When the first company of New England Congregationalist missionaries arrived in Hawaii in 1820, they encountered a society in political and cultural transition following the collapse of the kapu system the year before. Working closely with the new Hawaiian ruling class (which had its own reasons for embracing a new religious framework), the missionaries within 20 years had created a printing press, a school system, a written constitution, and a legal code based on Puritan New England norms — and had transformed a society that had been organized around its own specific sacred hierarchy, gender protocols, and ceremonial calendar into a Calvinist Christian state that prohibited hula, restricted women's public movement, and criminalized traditional religious practice. The speed and completeness of the transformation was remarkable. Its cost — to the specific Hawaiian sacred world whose deep dive appears in this series — was immense.

The pattern repeats across geography and century. Cherokee traditional ceremonies were discouraged or prohibited by ABCFM missionaries while the same missionaries built schools and supported the Cherokee national infrastructure. Ari traditional sacred practices were actively displaced by SIM missionary churches that were simultaneously providing the only educational and medical services available in the region. The Asaro Mudmen of Papua New Guinea encountered missionaries who prohibited their sacred ceremonies while building schools. In community after community, the same exchange was offered: the sacred tradition for the school, the hospital, the literacy. The communities that accepted the exchange often made it because the material benefits were real and immediate. The sacred costs were only fully felt generations later.

What Was Gained — Education, Medicine, and Local Leadership

The Positive Account, Honestly Given

A complete account of the missionary tradition requires acknowledging what it built as well as what it destroyed. The honest reckoning is that the missionary movement created institutional infrastructure — schools, hospitals, literacy programs, translation, legal advocacy — in communities that colonial governments and commercial enterprises had neither the interest nor the incentive to serve.

The educational legacy is the most consistently significant. Mission schools were, in most of the regions where they operated, the only educational institutions available to indigenous populations. The graduates of mission schools became the leaders of independence movements — Kwame Nkrumah (Ghana), Julius Nyerere (Tanzania), Kenneth Kaunda (Zambia), Robert Mugabe (Zimbabwe), Jomo Kenyatta (Kenya) all received their formal education in mission schools, sometimes from missionary teachers who were themselves critical of colonial rule. The irony that mission education equipped the leadership of the movements that ended colonialism is one of the most significant and least acknowledged stories in African history.

The medical legacy is equally significant. Mission hospitals and clinics were the first and for decades the only healthcare infrastructure in large parts of sub-Saharan Africa, Asia, and the Pacific. The Albert Schweitzer Hospital at Lambaréné (Gabon, 1913), the Aga Khan hospitals of East Africa (which began as missionary institutions), the Mary Slessor Hospitals of Nigeria, and thousands of smaller mission clinics provided healthcare to populations that European colonial governments were not providing for. Mission medicine is contested — it came with the assumption that Western medicine was superior to indigenous healing traditions, often explicitly competing with traditional healers — but the material benefit of access to surgery, vaccination, and basic medical care was real and substantial.

The advocacy legacy is more uneven but present. The abolitionist movement in Britain and the United States was largely driven by evangelical Christians motivated by the same theological convictions that drove the missionary movement. The campaign to end the East African Arab slave trade was largely conducted by Christian missionaries. The campaign against foot-binding in China was missionary-driven. The campaign to end sati in India was supported by missionaries. The moral record of the missionary movement includes both the destruction of indigenous sacred traditions and the advocacy for the human dignity of the people who held those traditions — often by the same missionaries at the same moment.

Contextualization — The Central Theological Debate

How Much of the Culture Can Come With? How Much Must Go?

The central unresolved question of missionary theology is contextualization: how much of a recipient culture's existing practices, symbols, and frameworks can be retained, adapted, and incorporated into the Christian life of the new church? The question runs directly through the histories of every tradition in this series that has encountered Christian mission.

The spectrum of positions runs from what missiologists call "extraction" at one end (the new Christian must leave their culture entirely and adopt a new, Christianity-shaped identity that rejects all pre-Christian practice) to "transformation" in the middle (the gospel engages the culture, critiquing what is incompatible with Christian faith while affirming, adapting, and baptizing what can be redeemed) to "syncretism" at the other end (the gospel is fully absorbed into the existing culture, Christianity becoming one layer added to what was already there without significantly changing anything). Virtually all parties in the debate accuse their opponents of being either too extractive or too syncretistic, which tells you where they think the proper middle ground is.

The practical question that any missionary faces when arriving in a new community: is the harvest festival a sacred ceremony to be prohibited or a cultural event that can be Christianized? Is the ancestor veneration a form of idolatry to be opposed or an expression of family loyalty that Christianity can affirm? Is the healing ceremony conducted by the traditional specialist the work of the devil or an indigenous engagement with the sacred that points, however imperfectly, toward the same God that the missionary proclaims? These questions have been answered differently by different missionaries in the same communities, producing very different outcomes for the sacred traditions those communities maintained.

The Lausanne Covenant's Paragraph 10 committed evangelical mission to the principle that "missions have all too frequently exported with the gospel an alien culture, and this is not the same as the gospel." The practical implementation of this principle has been uneven. The recognition that contextualization is necessary has not resolved the question of where the line is. Every missionary tradition continues to debate it.

The Unreached Peoples Concept

The Strategic Lens of Contemporary Evangelical Mission

The unreached peoples concept — the understanding that the fundamental unit of missionary strategy is the ethnolinguistic people group, and that the mission task is not complete until every such group has an indigenous church — has been the dominant strategic framework of evangelical mission since Ralph Winter's 1974 Lausanne presentation. Its implications are significant and deserve examination.

The concept defines "unreached" as a people group in which less than 2% of the population is evangelical Christian and less than 5% is Christian of any kind — with the specific threshold being the percentage believed necessary for an indigenous church to be self-sustaining without outside missionary assistance. By this definition, the Joshua Project currently identifies approximately 7,400 unreached people groups with a combined population of approximately 3.2 billion people, representing roughly 42% of the global population.

The strategic implications are significant. The unreached peoples concept directs missionary resources toward ethnic and linguistic minorities, often in politically unstable or access-restricted regions, rather than toward geographic countries that already have Christian populations. It prioritizes presence among the least-reached rather than church growth among the already-reached. It has made ethnolinguistic mapping a major enterprise of evangelical mission organizations, producing databases (the Joshua Project, the IMB's unreached peoples database) that track the religious composition of thousands of population groups worldwide.

The concept is also contested. Critics from within missiology argue that the 2%/5% threshold is arbitrary, that the "unreached" designation ignores the complexity of how people actually engage with religion, and that the focus on ethnic group identity can reinforce ethnic divisions rather than the cross-cultural community that Christian theology holds as an ideal. Critics from outside argue that the concept instrumentalizes human communities as targets of religious conversion rather than recognizing their existing spiritual lives as legitimate.

Short-Term Mission Trips

The Most Widespread and Most Debated Form of Contemporary Mission

Since the 1970s, the short-term mission trip — typically a week to two months spent by volunteers from wealthy countries in poorer countries, conducting evangelism, construction, medical clinics, or children's programs — has become one of the most widespread practices in American evangelical Christianity. Estimates suggest that approximately 2 million Americans participate in short-term mission trips each year, spending approximately $3–$4 billion annually. Short-term trips are the primary form of missionary experience for most evangelical Christians in the United States.

The criticism of the short-term mission model is extensive, well-documented, and largely justified. The classic critique, articulated by development economists and missiologists alike: short-term mission trips often benefit the participants more than the communities they visit. They are typically designed around the participants' schedule and skill level rather than the community's actual needs. The construction work done by unskilled volunteers often needs to be redone by local craftspeople after the team leaves. The medical clinics, however well-intentioned, can undermine local healthcare providers by providing free services that the community then expects permanently. The cultural contact, however meaningful to the participants, is often superficial and sometimes disrespectful. The resources spent on the trip — airfare, accommodation, food — could in most cases accomplish more if donated directly to local organizations.

The defense of the short-term model argues that the primary value is mobilization: short-term trips create participants who return to their home communities committed to long-term involvement in mission, either as career missionaries or as long-term donors. The experience of encounter with global poverty and with the global church is understood as formative for the participant in ways that have long-term consequences. The question of whether those long-term consequences justify the costs — financial, cultural, and ethical — of the short-term encounter is one that the missionary movement continues to debate.

Controversies

The Ongoing Conversations That Define Contemporary Mission

The John Allen Chau Controversy

In November 2018, John Allen Chau — a 26-year-old American evangelical missionary trained by All Nations, an organization focused on unreached peoples — landed on North Sentinel Island in the Indian Ocean, which is inhabited by the Sentinelese, one of the last fully uncontacted peoples on earth. Contact with the Sentinelese is illegal under Indian law, which protects North Sentinel Island to preserve the Sentinelese community from external contact that could expose them to diseases to which they have no immunity. Chau had arranged illegal transport to the island. He was killed by Sentinelese archers on his third attempt to land.

Chau's death generated international debate that crystallized the central tensions of contemporary mission. The missionary community largely honored his courage and faith while debating the wisdom of his methods. The indigenous rights community argued that his actions constituted both illegal trespass and a genuine threat to the Sentinelese's survival — and that his death, while tragic, was a foreseeable consequence of violating the most basic protocols of indigenous peoples' rights. The secular press framed the story largely as an account of religious fanaticism. The debate exposed the fault lines between the missionary tradition's theological conviction (souls in need of salvation) and the indigenous rights tradition's political conviction (peoples in need of protection from external contact).

The Gospel and Culture Debate

The contextualization debate described earlier has sharpened in the 21st century around specific cases. The Insider Movement — a missiological strategy that argues Muslim-background believers can remain within Islamic cultural and community structures while holding Christian faith — has divided evangelical mission thinkers. Its proponents argue that it allows the gospel to spread within Muslim communities without the cultural displacement that traditional conversion demands. Its critics argue that it asks believers to maintain a divided identity that is intellectually and spiritually unsustainable, and that it fails to call converts to the Christian community that is the normal context of Christian discipleship.

The New Apostolic Reformation (NAR) Controversy

The New Apostolic Reformation — a loosely organized movement within Pentecostal Christianity that claims a new era of apostolic authority and direct divine revelation — has become one of the most influential and most controversial forces in contemporary evangelical mission. NAR-affiliated missionaries have been active in Africa, Asia, and Latin America with a specific emphasis on "spiritual warfare" — the casting out of demons from communities and territories as the prerequisite for church planting. Critics within evangelical missiology argue that NAR's theology is aberrant and its methods are harmful. Critics from indigenous communities argue that NAR's spiritual warfare framing specifically targets indigenous sacred practitioners and ceremonies as demonic, making it among the most aggressively culture-destroying mission theologies in the current era.

The Decolonization Question

Contemporary missiology is increasingly engaged with the demand for decolonization — the dismantling of the colonial power structures that the missionary movement helped create and maintain. For some missiologists, decolonization means acknowledging the historical harm of the missionary movement and committing to modes of partnership with non-Western churches that respect their autonomy and theological judgment. For others, it means questioning whether Western missionary enterprise should continue at all. The Lausanne Movement's Cape Town Commitment (2010) and its subsequent documents increasingly address the decolonization question directly, acknowledging the colonial legacy while maintaining the theological conviction that the Great Commission remains binding.

The Haligric Lens

What the Missionary Tradition Offers and What It Demands in Return

The missionary tradition occupies a unique position in the Haligricity library. Unlike every other tradition covered here, which is documented for its own sake as an expression of human sacred life worth understanding, the missionary tradition appears in this library primarily as the external force most consistently present in the disruption of the other traditions. The Ari, the Banna, the Hawaiian, the Cherokee, the Guaraní, the Asaro, and dozens of others in this series have had their sacred worlds touched, disrupted, or transformed by Christian missionaries. The missionary document is the account of the institution that most frequently appears in those other documents as the agent of change.

The Haligric framework holds that every sacred tradition deserves honest account — including its shadow, its costs, and its failures — and that the honest account is more valuable than a sanitized one. The missionary tradition's shadow is real and documented: the suppression of indigenous sacred traditions, the entanglement with colonialism, the paternalism, and the cultural destruction. The missionary tradition's gift is also real: the hospitals, the schools, the translation work, the individual practitioners who gave their lives in genuine service.

What the missionary encounter reveals about sacred knowledge, from a Haligric perspective, is this: that the conviction that one possesses the exclusive truth is among the most powerful forces in human history, capable of generating both extraordinary self-sacrifice and extraordinary harm depending on how it interacts with the specific conditions of the encounter. The missionaries who went into the interior of Africa and Asia and the Americas were, by any measure, people of remarkable courage and commitment. They were also people whose specific theological certainty made it nearly impossible for them to recognize the validity of what they were encountering. The Haligric tradition holds that every sacred tradition carries specific knowledge of the divine that cannot be possessed by any single tradition. The missionary tradition's most persistent failure has been the inability to hold that understanding alongside the conviction of the Great Commission.

Grand Rising. William Carey arrived in India in 1793 and never went home. Hudson Taylor put on Chinese clothing and walked into the interior. The five men in Ecuador were speared to death by the people they had come to reach, and the people who killed them eventually buried them and then buried their resentment alongside them and became something new. Mary Slessor walked barefoot into the Nigerian bush and told the people she found there that they could not kill the twins anymore. The missionaries built schools in communities that had no schools and suppressed ceremonies in communities that had no other way of transmitting sacred knowledge. The Global South churches they planted are now sending missionaries back to the countries the missionaries came from. The tradition has never been simple. It has never been one thing. What it has always been is human beings acting on the conviction that what they know is worth dying for and crossing oceans for and learning languages for — and that conviction, whatever you think of the theology it was attached to, is itself a sacred phenomenon. Grand Rising.